

# DEATH IN THE NILGIRIS

David Davidar's new novel, set in the backdrop of Ayodhya, is a secular idealist's rejoinder to the profanities of faith



**THE SOLITUDE OF EMPERORS**  
by DAVID DAVIDAR  
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■ By S. Prasannarajan

Novelists have to be careful when gods are angry, when narratives sanctioned by the misread Book are pitted against the lyricism of our everyday existence. It's your word against the Word, which today reaches us in its crackling, disembodied horror through mysterious videotapes. The Word, manufactured by the paranoia of religion, has to be repudiated. Still, novelists usually don't fall to the temptations of the headlines; they don't compete with editorialists and columnists. Remember, it took a while for the 9/11 novel to make its entry, ranging from Jonathan Safran Foer's *Extremely Loud and Incredibly Close* to Ian McEwan's *Saturday* to Don DeLillo's *Falling Man*. God, certainly, is the biggest story of the times. You don't have to go all the way to the scalded streets of Mesopotamia or the ghettos of the Middle East to get an idea of the new—the oldest, really—weapon of mass destruction: religion.

We have been living through it with admirable stoicism. Ayodhya, Bombay, Ahmedabad... and the sanguineous politics of gods becomes a text that can no longer be understood by the simple rules of good and evil, of victimhood and villainy. It is steeped so irredeemably in mythology and pathology, in the exaggerations of national hurt. And it is being manipulated by fundamentalists from the right as well as the left. David Davidar's second novel is an audacious trip beyond the headlines, into the remote recesses of hate sanctified by religion. *The Solitude of Emperors* is a novel with a political

conscience, written by someone whose memory is scarred by the profanities of faith. Elegiac and elegant, it traverses the realms of dissent and idealism, of the martyrdom of the outcast and the make-believe of the rioter. It is a novel India can't afford to ignore.

Ayodhya made it happen. Says Davidar, "Yes, Ayodhya saddened me, forced me to think about things I had taken for granted, such as secularism, the place of religion in our everyday life and so on. But subconsciously maybe this was something I had always been concerned with and Ayodhya actively set me thinking about these issues—and the process culminated in the novel." Ayodhya is the process that takes the young Vijay, the narrator, from K, a small town in Tamil Nadu, to Bombay—and to the sagely editor of *The Indian Secularist*, Rustom Sorabjee, the benevolent lord of Jehangir Mansion. As Vijay, protégé of secular journalism's lone warrior, gives in to the whirling vitality of the city with infinite possibilities, something snaps and Bombay breaks apart, "its industriousness and resilience a sham, a thin veil that covered the deep-seated fear and suspicion that had taken hold of its inhabitants". In the post-Ayodhya riots, Vijay comes intimately closer to the fury of the streets. The riot transforms him, and as the streets erupt to bloodlust, Vijay ceases to be a detached witness.

Bombay prepares him to become part of the story, which will be played out elsewhere, in the misty hills of the Nilgiris. Sorabjee sends him on a working holiday: recover from the Bombay shock in the cool environs of Meham in a bungalow owned by a friend of the editor's and write a report on the controversy surrounding the Tower of God, the communal angle of which has a Bombay connection. The mentor also wants him to read the manuscript of



**DISSENTING DAVIDAR:** "The cynical misuse of religion is disturbing"

*The Solitude of Emperors: Why Ashoka, Akbar and Gandhi Matter to Us Today*, which he has written as an inspirational text for the youth. It's Sorabjee's manifesto against sectarianism, and his helpline to the young and the vulnerable, who are potential recruits for the fundamentalists. He wants Vijay's opinion before it is sent to the publish-